

July 15, 1943

MEMORANDUM FOR THE FILE

Subject: Conference Re Program for Evacuation of Jews from Rumania.

Present: State Department: Messrs. Reams, Melner and Kuppinger.
Treasury Department: Messrs. Pehle, DuBois and Olsen.

The conference was called in order to explore in a preliminary way the various problems raised in the proposal of the American Jewish Congress to undertake a program of evacuating approximately 70,000 Jews from Rumania. It will be recalled that the American Jewish Congress has been advised by a representative of the World Jewish Congress in Geneva that certain Rumanian officials can be bribed at a cost of approximately 100,000,000 lei (about \$170,000) to permit the evacuation of these Jews. While the details of the program and the cable messages relating thereto are somewhat garbled, it is understood that the Rumanian officials will be paid in local currency held by a group of wealthy Jewish merchants who in turn will have deposited to their credit an equivalent amount of blocked dollars or Swiss francs converted at black market rates.

Mr. Reams, a Foreign Service Officer presently assigned to the European division and also serving as the State Department's refugee expert, summarized the current status of several inter-governmental programs for the evacuation of Jews from Europe. He stated that a comprehensive plan for the evacuation of Jews from Bulgaria and Rumania had broken down due to the lack of transportation facilities necessary to remove them from the area. He stated that the only way that they could be evacuated at the present time is by sea to Palestine. There had been considerable negotiation for the use of two Rumanian boats interned at Istanbul for the evacuation of the Jews. The boats were to be manned by Turkish seamen and fly a Turkish flag. Mr. Reams stated that these negotiations failed to materialize and since that date there have been no prospects of working out alternative methods of effecting the evacuation of these Jews.

Mr. Reams pointed out that under the provisions of the British White Paper only about 30,000 Jews can be admitted to Palestine. He said he did not know of any other areas to which the remaining Jews could be evacuated since the Turkish Government has refused entry to Jewish refugees and so far the North African military authorities have, for military reasons, been unwilling to permit their entry into Africa.

There then was considerable discussion with respect to the difficult financial and communication aspects involved in such a program. It was generally agreed that many details of the proposed program should